

and raw-pine settlements had mushroomed overnight around newly discovered oil fields and newly established drilling sites. Most grown men habitually carried six-guns strapped to their waists; shooting affrays were everyday commonplaces.

The oil-field workers and wildcatters were certainly hard, tough and virile, but I can remember many of the toughest among them dressing up in their Sunday best and going to Oklahoma City or Tulsa to hear a touring opera company or a concert artist perform.

When they struck it rich, a great many oil men—I might even say most—bought or built homes and purchased paintings, sculpture and antique furniture and rugs for them. They also went East, to New York, to see the plays and hear the operas and concerts.

True, their tastes were seldom refined or matured—at least not at first. But the fact remains that these rugged, hard-bitten men *did* thirst for artistic beauty, and they

did take an active interest in and show appreciation for things cultural. By no means were they the culture phobes that so many modern Americans think all frontiersmen and old timers were and whose imagined example they seek to

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emulate in order to prove themselves rugged, two-fisted all-male men.

There are other factors that help produce such a high proportion of educated barbarians among American men—

but, regardless of the causes, the results are deplorable.

The saddest part of the whole situation is that the United States *does* possess outstanding cultural institutions and facilities. American symphony orchestras and opera companies are among the finest in the world.

American museums and art galleries—public and private—